

## Week 4 / Tuesday

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# Buddha



**Figure:** One representation of Buddha (among many).

# Dates

c. 450 BCE

## (Mythical) Context

- ▶ Abandoned a wealthy/powerful position when he witnessed suffering (which was hidden from him).
- ▶ Engaged in ascetic practices but found them ineffective.
- ▶ Meditated for forty-nine days and achieved "enlightenment."

# Four "Truths" of Buddhism

- ▶ Suffering exists.
- ▶ Suffering comes from individualistic desires and cravings. (Good food, social success, etc.)
- ▶ You can end suffering by letting go of your individualistic desires and cravings.
- ▶ The way to do that is the "Eightfold Path."

# The Eightfold Path

- ▶ Right View
- ▶ Right Intention
- ▶ Right Action
- ▶ Right Livelihood
- ▶ Right Effort
- ▶ Right Mindfulness
- ▶ Right Concentration
- ▶ Right Speech

# "Right"

"Here again the word "Right" is not a moral judgment to be contrasted with bad or wrong, but means 'leading to happiness for oneself and others.' (Beth Roth)

# Compassion (*Karuna*)

"What sets his teachings apart . . . lies in what he says that ignorance consists in the conceit that there is an 'I' and a 'mine'. This is the famous Buddhist teaching of non-self (anātman)."  
(Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy)

Note that Buddha and Buddhists fully accept that the idea of having a self is useful and necessary in many contexts.

# Karma

- ▶ Intentional action
  - ▶ Bodily
  - ▶ Verbal
  - ▶ Mental
- ▶ Cause and effect

# Right Speech

- ▶ Not lying
- ▶ Not being divisive
- ▶ Not speaking abusively
- ▶ Avoiding idle chatter

# Five Factors of Right Speech

- ▶ Timely
- ▶ Truthful
- ▶ Beneficial/useful
- ▶ Affectionate
- ▶ Said with goodwill

# Communication as a Form of Compassion

"One should speak only pleasant words, words which are acceptable to others. What one speaks without bringing evils to others is pleasant." (Buddha)

What does it mean only to communicate words that do no harm?

# Communication is Related to All Other Activities

"One tries to abandon wrong speech & to enter into right speech: This is one's right effort. One is mindful to abandon wrong speech & to enter & remain in right speech: This is one's right mindfulness. Thus these three qualities — right view, right effort, & right mindfulness — run & circle around right speech." (Buddha)

# The Importance of Reflection/Listening

"We need to lie, exaggerate, embellish, use harsh and aggressive speech, engage in useless banter, and speak at inappropriate times, in order to experience how using speech in these ways creates tension in the body, agitation in the mind, and remorse in the heart. We also discover how unskillful speech degrades personal relationships and diminishes the possibility of peace in our world."  
(Beth Roth)

# Engaged Buddhism

"I talked with [my son] about how important and complex listening is, and how the inability to communicate with patience and respect not only damages interpersonal relationships but also contributes to the many problems threatening our world." (Roth)

# Buddhist Rhetoric

- ▶ Listening
- ▶ Personal reflection before and after communication
- ▶ An emphasis on compassionate and kind communication
- ▶ Skepticism toward explicit argument
- ▶ A general lack of focus on political/governmental concerns (unlike other traditions we've observed)
- ▶ An attitude that communication should always work to reduce conflict and selfishness